Codex or Claude Code?

Choose the agent for this job. Then make it earn the next one.

01 Can you define a passing result?

NO: write the outcome and three checks first. YES: continue below.

02 How much of the job is understood?

CLEAR + BOUNDED

Start with Codex

A defined page, known change or reproducible fix. Give it the files, constraints and passing checks. Run one capped trial.

UNCLEAR + INTERCONNECTED

Try Claude for diagnosis

For a tangled codebase or unclear bug, request a read-only plan with evidence first. Approve a small testable change next.

These are starting hypotheses. Either tool can do either job. Your own passing checks decide.

03 Did it pass every check within your cap?

YES: keep that agent for the next similar task.
NO: inspect the failure. If it repeats after a focused correction, stop and try the other agent from the same starting files.

Choose on total effort: usage cost + your review and repair time. If neither result passes, reduce the scope or bring in a human reviewer.

Before either tool acts: use a recoverable copy and only the access needed. Changes to payments, authentication or production data need a human review before release.

Make the choice measurable.

Use the same starting files, brief and checks for both agents.

THE TASK AND THE EXACT MODEL / SETTINGS

THREE CHECKS THAT PROVE IT WORKS

CAPS: USAGE / SPEND, ELAPSED TIME, AND WHEN TO STOP

PASTE INTO EITHER AGENT

Work on this bounded task: [task]. Use [starting files] and follow [constraints]. A passing result must satisfy [three checks]. First inspect the relevant files. If the approach is unclear, return an evidence-backed plan before editing. Otherwise implement the smallest complete change and run the checks. Stay within [time and usage limits]; if you cannot measure a limit, say so before starting. Stop on repeated failure or missing access. Return the changed files, check results, unresolved issues and measured usage. Do not deploy.

RECORD BOTH RESULTS

For each: exact model/settings, checks passed, billed usage (or unavailable), elapsed time, and your review/repair minutes. Keep the lowest total effort among results that pass.

Example: a defined landing page starts with a Codex trial. An intermittent checkout bug starts with diagnosis and a safe reproduction. Approve a fix only after the failure is reproduced and the check passes.

Evidence note: the Reel cites Nate Herk's eight-site comparison. He reported approximate API estimates of $100 vs $444 and runtimes of 5 vs 14 hours. That test does not establish which agent wins on every complex codebase. This framework is a practical synthesis, not a replicated benchmark.

Nate Herk: test report Claude: verification Codex: task prompts